

KEEPING THE SEASON

Dry a stem, keep a month



The loveliest autumn ritual costs nothing and lasts all winter: drying the season to keep it. Cut grasses, seed heads, hydrangea, branches of turned leaves at their peak. Bundle the stems loosely, tie them, and hang them upside down in a dim, dry corner for two or three weeks. Hung in the dark, they hold their colour; dried in light, they fade.

Then arrange them as you would a single fresh stem — three, varied in height, in a terracotta vase, with a great deal of air around them. You have made *mono no aware* into an object you can keep: the season caught at the moment of its turning, held against the dark months. It is the most Japandi thing you can do with a pair of scissors and a quiet corner.

"Hang them in the dark to keep the colour. The season is preserved by being hidden first."